

The Definition of Love



POEM TEXT

- 1 My love is of a birth as rare
- 2 As 'tis for object strange and high;
- 3 It was begotten by Despair
- 4 Upon Impossibility.
- 5 Magnanimous Despair alone
- 6 Could show me so divine a thing
- 7 Where feeble Hope could ne'er have flown,
- 8 But vainly flapp'd its tinsel wing.
- 9 And yet I quickly might arrive
- 10 Where my extended soul is fixt,
- 11 But Fate does iron wedges drive,
- 12 And always crowds itself betwixt.
- 13 For Fate with jealous eye does see
- 14 Two perfect loves, nor lets them close;
- 15 Their union would her ruin be,
- 16 And her tyrannic pow'r depose.
- 17 And therefore her decrees of steel
- 18 Us as the distant poles have plac'd,
- 19 (Though love's whole world on us doth wheel)
- 20 Not by themselves to be embrac'd;
- 21 Unless the giddy heaven fall,
- 22 And earth some new convulsion tear;
- 23 And, us to join, the world should all
- 24 Be cramp'd into a planisphere.
- 25 As lines, so loves oblique may well
- 26 Themselves in every angle greet;
- 27 But ours so truly parallel,
- 28 Though infinite, can never meet.
- 29 Therefore the love which us doth bind,
- 30 But Fate so enviously debars,
- 31 Is the conjunction of the mind,
- 32 And opposition of the stars.



SUMMARY

My love's origins are as unusual and grand as the object of my affections is unlikely. My love's father was Despair, and its mother was Impossibility.

Only generous Despair could reveal a love so glorious to me. Hope could never have gotten me there; it would just have feebly flapped its fragile, glittery little wings.

Yet I could reach my beloved—the spot where my soul is anchored—in mere moments, if only Fate didn't keep trying to sever our connection, shoving itself between us to keep us apart.

For Fate looks jealously on two profound loves and doesn't let them come together. If two such loves could meet, they'd destroy Fate, knocking her from her cruel throne.

Thus, Fate has decreed that my beloved and I should be as permanently separate as the North and South Poles (though the love between us is so deep that it shoots right through the world, like the globe's axis). Like the poles, we will never be able to touch each other.

The only way we might ever come together is if the heavens themselves fell from their place and the earth were shaken by some vast earthquake—a cataclysm that flattened the whole world into a two-dimensional map of itself.

Less perfect loves, like curving lines of latitude, can meet and form angles. But our loves are so perfectly parallel to each other that they can reach out forever—but will never touch.

And so, the love that binds us together, but that Fate forbids, is a matter of two perfectly aligned minds opposed by the stars of destiny.



THEMES



THE POWER AND BEAUTY OF HOPELESS LOVE

The speaker of "The Definition of Love" is grappling with a hopeless love. This person's feelings for a beloved were "begotten by Despair / Upon Impossibility," meaning despair and impossibility were this love's father and mother. Yet the fact that the speaker can beloved can never be together is precisely what makes this love particularly "rare" (that is, both unusual and rich). In this poem, then, love that persists without hope is more powerful and more perfect than consummated love could ever be.

Though the speaker never explains precisely *why* this love is

hopeless, it's clear that there's no getting around it: Fate herself ([personified](#) as a "jealous" tyrant queen) stymies the would-be couple at every turn, driving "iron wedges" between them. The pair, then, is left to love each other without hope, as permanently and definitionally separate from each other as the earth's two "distant poles."

But it's precisely this distance that makes their love profound. In the [conceit](#) of the lovers as poles, their love becomes the axis of a "whole world of love": crossing the otherwise unbridgeable gap between them, love becomes the imaginary central line around which the world spins. That can only happen *because* they can't be together. Similarly, the speaker suggests, their loves for each other are so perfect they're like a pair of parallel lines: identical in every particular, and *for that very reason* unable to touch.

In this vision, impossible love is purest and most powerful because it persists in spite of a lack of love's natural reward: togetherness. On the one hand, that's an idealistic, romantic view, suggesting that the most perfect loves transcend reward, or are their own reward. On the other, it might simply be realistic, or even a little cynical, implying that a love that can't be acted on is always going to be more "perfect" than a love lived out by two flawed human beings. Either way, this poem's visions of geometrical perfection describe a love only made more profound and more lovely by its impossibility. A "definition" of love—in the sense of "limit" or "boundary"—also becomes its "definition," the conditions that define what love is in its purest form.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-32



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-4

*My love is of a birth as rare
As 'tis for object strange and high;
It was begotten by Despair
Upon Impossibility.*

"The Definition of Love" begins with a "rare" birth—that is, a birth that's both unusual and glorious. The speaker's love (meaning not an actual *beloved*, but an *emotion*) was born from the conjunction of two unlikely parents: its father is "Despair," and its mother is "Impossibility."

In other words, this love was doomed from the start. From the very moment of its birth to those strange [personified](#) parents, this was a love that could never be realized; it was the kind of impossible love that might drive one to despair.

But this impossibility, the speaker will go on to say, is exactly

what makes this love so powerful. The certainty that the speaker can never be with a beloved proves that love's intensity—and sharpens it. Despair doesn't kill the speaker's love, but *creates* it.

The speaker will reveal the "Definition of Love" in more than one sense, then. The poem will define love here as one defines any word: by showing what it is and what it means. But it will also explore its definition in the sense of its *limitation*, the boundaries that define it. This [paradoxical](#) brain-twister of a poem will find love in the place where the infinite meets the impossible.

Despite its complex ideas, "The Definition of Love" uses a deceptively simple form. Its eight [quatrains](#) (or four-line stanzas) are rhymed ABAB and written in [iambic](#) tetrameter (lines of four iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "My **love** | is of | a **birth** | as **rare**"). This shape, straightforward as a folk song's, will frame a lofty, cerebral vision of impossible love.

LINES 5-8

*Magnanimous Despair alone
Could show me so divine a thing
Where feeble Hope could ne'er have flown,
But vainly flapp'd its tinsel wing.*

Only Despair could have allowed the speaker to reach "so divine a thing" as this love. "[F]eeble Hope" could never have gotten the speaker there under its own power.

In other words, the beloved is so very far out of the speaker's reach, an "object" (or goal) so very "strange and high," that the speaker would never have dared *dream* they might be together. "Hope," in these circumstances, simply wouldn't have had the muscle. [Personifying](#) hope as a sad little bird with a useless "tinsel wing"—that is, shimmery-but-fake wings that aren't getting anyone off the ground—the speaker makes it clear how impossible this love has always seemed.

Perhaps that rather touching image also captures some of the speaker's own vulnerability in the face of hopeless love. The [alliterative](#) /f/ sounds of "flown" and "flapp'd" even let readers hear Hope's tiny, useless wingbeats, making the lovestruck speaker's powerlessness tangible.

This love was "begotten by Despair," then, in the sense that the speaker fell in love *right through* this despair, perhaps even *because* of this despair. That makes Despair "magnanimous," generous: it's only through knowing Despair that the speaker could have fallen so deeply in love. The kind of love that persists without hope, in this image, is a great, powerful, painful gift—even a "divine" one.

LINES 9-12

*And yet I quickly might arrive
Where my extended soul is fixt,*

*But Fate does iron wedges drive,
And always crowds itself betwixt.*

By this point, the reader may wonder: what exactly is it that keeps the speaker and beloved apart? Why is this love so impossible?

For a moment, the speaker seems to wonder this themselves. "And yet," the speaker muses, in spite of everything that gets in their way, perhaps they *could* be with their beloved. They could rush right to the place where their "extended soul is fixt"—that is, to this lover, the person in whose heart the speaker feels as if their soul is anchored. In this image, love indeed *extends* the speaker: to love, for the speaker, is to feel as if one's soul has stretched out away from the body and rooted itself in a beloved, connecting them across any gulf. (That's all very romantic, but readers wouldn't be wrong to see a sexual image here, too; more than the speaker's *soul* might be yearning for this beloved.)

But no: Fate itself stands in the way. In fact, through more [personification](#), Fate here *literally* stands in the way, "crowd[ing] itself betwixt" (or "between") the speaker and beloved, the world's least pleasant third wheel. Destiny, in other words, simply says "no" to this love.

As if that weren't enough, Fate drives "iron wedges" between the lovers—impediments like clumsy axe blades. Perhaps this [metaphor](#) even implies that Fate is doing its best to slice through the speaker's "extended soul," severing the connection between the pair.

Fate's intrusion here might raise more questions for the reader than it answers. The reader still doesn't know what form Fate is taking: whether Fate keeps the lovers apart through geographical distance or unfortunate circumstances (like a marriage to someone else) or class differences or forbidden sexualities or any number of other classic love problems. But then, in some sense, it just doesn't matter. Destiny is destiny, and whatever tools Fate uses here, the speaker and beloved are at its mercy.

LINES 13-16

*For Fate with jealous eye does see
Two perfect loves, nor lets them close;
Their union would her ruin be,
And her tyrannic pow'r depose.*

Fate isn't just doing her normal job here, the speaker goes on—not just impersonally decreeing how things will be. Rather, she's interfering with the lovers because she hates and fears love. And she is a *she*, now, distinctly: where Fate was an "it" in the previous stanza, she's now taken on the character of a very feminine "jealous" tyrant, a kind of cruel queen. This more specific [personification](#) might even suggest a love triangle (especially considering that earlier image of Fate wedging herself between the lovers).

"Two perfect loves," the speaker says, are Fate's enemy, a challenge to her authority: "their union would her ruin be." The consummation of a perfect love, in other words, flies in the face of Fate; it's somehow a danger to the orderly proceedings of destiny. If two true lovers could be together, then, they would "depose" Fate, knocking her from her throne.

These lines present Fate as love's enemy and thus suggest that love is a force outside of and opposed to Fate. Perhaps that seems strange: powerful Fate, after all, might be imagined as the conductor of all earthly events. But in these lines, it seems it wasn't Fate's work, wasn't destiny, that the speaker should *love* this beloved. That love must have been, in some way, a choice, an act not of fate but of the speaker's own free will.

Perhaps the lines introducing this love's parents—Despair and Impossibility, remember—reflect just how much of a choice loving was for the speaker and beloved. Seeing from the start that their love was impossible, the pair could have turned aside from their feelings and tried their best to forget. But they didn't.

If these two lovers should "close" (or come together), then, Fate would truly be defied. But Fate is just powerful enough that she's not going to let that happen.

By personifying Fate as a jealous woman, the poem provides a contrast with the kind of love the speaker and beloved share. Fate is "jealous" because she wants to maintain her power over the lovers, keeping them under her sway—a kind of self-serving relationship that readers may well recognize from life. The lovers, on the other hand, find their power through submission to what they can't change. Their choice to love on in spite of their helplessness to alter their circumstances is a strange, upside-down act of self-sacrificing courage.

LINES 17-20

*And therefore her decrees of steel
Us as the distant poles have plac'd,
(Though love's whole world on us doth wheel)
Not by themselves to be embrac'd;*

To preserve her power, Fate enacts one of her "decrees of steel"—her unbending laws. (The [metaphor](#), like the "iron wedges" she drives between the lovers, suggests a chilly, metallic, unfeeling quality in this cruel goddess, as well as an absoluteness.) The lovers, Fate commands, shall be as permanently separate from each other as the "distant poles," the utmost top and bottom of the earth. By *definition*, then, the two can never "be embrac'd," can never touch each other.

But this [conceit](#) opens up rich romantic possibilities. If the lovers are the North and South Poles, then the love that stretches between them (as in the speaker's earlier image of the "extended soul") forms the axis of the earth, the turning point, the imaginary line around which "love's whole world [...]" wheel[s]. By being so fully and permanently and definitionally

apart, the two are also deeply connected; their constancy in spite of separation makes their love the perfect center of "love's whole world."

Besides containing this complex emotional point in one potent image, this conceit puts the speaker's love into a cosmos of its own—and suggests that it's of cosmic importance, at least to these two lovers. Love *creates* a "whole world" here, a spinning globe among stars.

LINES 21-24

*Unless the giddy heaven fall,
And earth some new convulsion tear;
And, us to join, the world should all
Be cramp'd into a planisphere.*

The only way that the lovers' two [metaphorical](#) "poles" could meet, the speaker imagines, is through a cosmic disaster. If the "giddy heaven" (the dizzily high sky) were to fall from its place; if the world were to be ripped apart by "some new convulsion," some vast earthquake; if the resultant halves of the world were to be crushed flat, so that the globe were "cramp'd into a planisphere," laid out like a two-dimensional map—*then*, and only then, the poles could be made to touch, the lovers could be together.

Once again, there's geometrical wit at play here. The wonderful image of "love's whole world" being "cramp'd into a planisphere" cleverly solves the problem of poles being definitionally opposite. A planisphere is a kind of map that represents spherical shapes on a plane. Flattened out as if on paper, the poles could be made to touch simply by halving the globe at the right spot and arranging the poles next to each other.

Perhaps this image poignantly hints that two-dimensional worlds are the only ones in which the lovers can be together: the planisphere, yes, but also the paper upon which the speaker writes these words.

The image of falling stars and an earth ripped apart might also carry echoes of the Book of Revelation (the Christian vision of apocalypse, in which the stars are prophesied to [fall from the heavens](#)). Like [John Donne's lovers](#) reuniting at the graveside on Judgment Day, this pair might meet at the end of the world—but not before.

LINES 25-28

*As lines, so loves oblique may well
Themselves in every angle greet;
But ours so truly parallel,
Though infinite, can never meet.*

The speaker now returns to that imagined globe (the unflattened version) to find another [metaphor](#) for this predicament. This time, the speaker looks to the difference between lines of longitude and latitude.

"Oblique" lines—lines of longitude, which criss-cross at the poles—are like lesser loves, the speaker says: they can "themselves in every angle greet." In other words, loves that are a little misaligned, a little out of tune with each other, a little imperfect, eventually run into each other. Such loves aren't impossible or doomed. (There's even the slight [punny](#) suggestion that these loves end up being consummated in "every angle"—that is, furtively, in any hidden corner one might care to peek into. Not terribly romantic.)

But that's not the kind of love the speaker and beloved feel. Their loves, the speaker says, are "truly parallel": like lines of latitude, they run around the globe without ever slanting and without ever touching each other, making "infinite" circles that "can never meet."

There's a dizzying chicken-and-egg quality to this new aspect of the speaker's [conceit](#). Here, the speaker and beloved can't be together because their love is perfect and infinite—and their love is perfect and infinite because they can't be together.

Readers might equally interpret this as an idealistic or a cynical moment:

- On the idealistic side, the speaker suggests that the pair's love is greater and purer because it can't be consummated: the two can never "meet," but remain constant and matched nonetheless. Their feelings, then, aren't just about pleasure-seeking: their love is bigger than a mere hunger for sex or companionship.
- On the cynical side, the speaker might hint that only loves that never get fulfilled *stay* perfect. A love that's never consummated can always be ideal; a love that is consummated will inevitably have to tangle with human imperfection.

Perhaps both of these things are true at once. Like perfection and impossibility, idealism and cynicism make strangely comfortable bedfellows here.

What's certain is that impossibility remains the dominant force in this love. The speaker and beloved have now metaphorically moved from the opposing poles of "love's whole world" to its lines of latitude. But shifting their position on the globe makes not one bit of difference. Wherever they go, whatever they do, they can't be together.

LINES 29-32

*Therefore the love which us doth bind,
But Fate so enviously debars,
Is the conjunction of the mind,
And opposition of the stars.*

The speaker rolls into the final stanza with a "Therefore," as if preparing to complete a proof—which, in a way, is just what the poem is doing. A conclusive "therefore" suits the speaker's

geographical object lessons and mathematical [conceits](#) of perfect love as opposite poles, or as parallel lines running endless rings around the earth.

The very shape of these closing lines mirrors the predicament the speaker has been exploring all along: that love's impossibility is also the source of its divinity and perfection. The speaker begins by setting up an opposition:

Therefore the love which us doth bind,
But Fate so enviously debars,

Love binds and Fate forbids; love connects and Fate splits apart. Even the echoing /d/ and /b/ sounds in "doth bind" and "debars" underscores the sense that connection and separation are [paradoxically](#) intertwined.

Then comes a second and conclusive opposition:

Is the conjunction of the mind,
And opposition of the stars.

The lovers' minds are in perfect alignment; their "stars," the forces determining their fates, are against them. The language of both of these statements is taken from stargazing. In a "conjunction," two celestial bodies align perfectly, so that they appear to merge.

Again, this is an image of minds working in parallel. Some lovers picture themselves [merging into one being](#) with their beloveds; this lover celebrates a tension between difference and similarity, an *apparent* union made possible by the fact that the two lovers are actually far apart. This paradox of connection through separation is both the pain and the great reward of this love.

And notice that it is *minds* here, not hearts or souls, that are in conjunction. To this cerebral speaker, the definition of love is a matter of thought as well as feeling.

world" spins: their love shoots right through the globe between them. This unlikely image uses the language of geography and cartography to depict relationship and connection across an otherwise unbridgeable distance. The poles, here, are linked *because* they can't be together; their opposition is also what unites them.

Developing the globe conceit further, the speaker and beloved from the poles to the lines of latitude. Like these imaginary lines—which run around the earth in perfectly parallel belts—the lovers' feelings for each other are matched, identical, and "infinite." The problem with parallel lines, of course, is that they "can never meet." This mathematical vision of love suggests that impossibility creates perfection, and perfection creates impossibility:

- On the one hand, this conceit romantically suggests that the most perfect love is one that can never be fulfilled. The fact that the pair go on loving each other in spite of their love's impossibility just goes to show how deep and pure their feelings are.
- On the other, there's a hint here that never getting to consummate one's love might also *keep* it perfect. More "oblique," slanted, imperfect loves might create an "angle," the speaker suggests—that is, they might touch, the lovers might come together. But they're also not so beautifully matched. The implication might be that the only perfect love is one that never gets lived out; any real-life relationship eventually destroys fantasies of perfection.

The poem's images of "conjunction" and "opposition" paint a picture of impossible love as a problem of inarguable geometry: these are just the *facts*. As parallel lines can never touch, as a pole is defined by being exactly opposite another pole, so these two lovers are forever aligned and forever separate.

Where Conceit appears in the poem:

- **Lines 17-24:** "And therefore her decrees of steel / Us as the distant poles have plac'd, / (Though love's whole world on us doth wheel) / Not by themselves to be embrac'd; / Unless the giddy heaven fall, / And earth some new convulsion tear; / And, us to join, the world should all / Be cramp'd into a planisphere."
- **Lines 25-28:** "As lines, so loves oblique may well / Themselves in every angle greet; / But ours so truly parallel, / Though infinite, can never meet."

PERSONIFICATION

By [personifying](#) the forces that made the speaker fall in love, then kept the speaker away from a beloved, the poem presents a vision of a world that's sometimes "magnanimous," sometimes "jealous," and often working actively against the lovers'



POETIC DEVICES

CONCEIT

This poem's speaker captures impossible love in the cerebral [conceit](#) (an elaborate [extended metaphor](#)) of "love's whole world" as a globe.

On this globe, the speaker and beloved are doomed to be opposite poles. In this metaphor, the pair can by definition never meet—at least, not unless some huge cataclysm shakes the heavens and the earth and collapses the world into a flat "planisphere," a map upon which the poles might be artificially *made* to touch.

But it's precisely because the lovers are as distant as the poles that their love can become the axis around which "love's whole

interests. The speaker and beloved, these personifications imply, are at the mercy of forces stronger than they are.

Right from the start, the speaker says, this love was doomed:

It was begotten by Despair
Upon Impossibility.

In other words, Despair was this love's father and Impossibility its mother. These are not necessarily the parents one might expect for a deep and perfect passion. But "Magnanimous Despair alone," the speaker says, was the only father this love could possibly have had. A love "so divine" as this one, in other words, was *always* going to feel as if it were out of reach. Mere "Hope," which the speaker presents here as a "feeble" little bird with a fragile "tinsel wing," couldn't possibly soar to this love's heights.

In other words, Despair is weirdly gracious here. The love the speaker feels is all the more powerful because it can never be consummated.

With such parents, the speaker knows, this love will never be realized in an actual relationship. Fate, in the form of a cruel woman, forbids it. The speaker's portrait of Fate might almost suggest a "jealous" lover: "enviously," she "crowds [...] betwixt" the speaker and beloved, getting in the way. But Fate also comes across as a witch or a goddess here, driving her "iron wedges" between the lovers in an exercise of "tyrannic pow'r." To be divided by Fate, this personification suggests, feels a lot like being impeded by an arbitrarily cruel authority.

Where Personification appears in the poem:

- **Lines 3-4:** "It was begotten by Despair / Upon Impossibility."
- **Lines 5-8:** "Magnanimous Despair alone / Could show me so divine a thing / Where feeble Hope could ne'er have flown, / But vainly flapp'd its tinsel wing."
- **Lines 11-12:** "But Fate does iron wedges drive, / And always crowds itself betwixt."
- **Lines 13-16:** "For Fate with jealous eye does see / Two perfect loves, nor lets them close; / Their union would her ruin be, / And her tyrannic pow'r depose."
- **Lines 17-18:** "And therefore her decrees of steel / Us as the distant poles have plac'd,"
- **Line 30:** "But Fate so enviously debar,"

PUN

"The Definition of Love" rests on a [pun](#). The word "Definition," here, can be read to mean both "explanation of meaning" (as in a dictionary definition) and "limit" or "boundary." The poem explains love, in other words, through limitations and impossibilities.

A love that can't ever be consummated in a relationship or sex

or even simple proximity might be imagined as a love stunted or frustrated. But in this speaker's terms, impossible love is the most "perfect" kind of love there is. Precisely because the poem's lovers can't be together, their persistent feelings for each other reveal what love can be when satisfaction isn't on the table. A love that persists in spite of separation is—well, the very *definition of love* in its purest form. A love that keeps going strong, without any reward beyond itself, demonstrates that love means something more than pleasure or sex or companionship.

That definition of love emerges from a love *defined* and bounded by impossibility, "begotten by Despair"—a love that just isn't going to be fulfilled, not on this earth. And yet, [paradoxically](#), that same impossible love is in many ways *unbounded*, infinite as parallel lines, more powerful than the limits that hold it back. The pun in the title suggests that love is best seen, most clearly revealed, in those cases where it can't simply be lived out.

Where Pun appears in the poem:

ALLITERATION

Flickers of [alliteration](#) highlight important moments in the poem like touches of gold leaf.

Listen, for instance, to the chimes in the second stanza:

Magnanimous Despair alone
Could show me so divine a thing
Where feeble Hope could ne'er have flown,
But vainly flapp'd its tinsel wing.

The subtle echoing /d/ of "Despair" and "divine" quietly echoes the speaker's point here: this love is divine precisely *because* it's impossible, its holiness and its hopelessness are linked. The /f/ sound of "flown" and "flapp'd," meanwhile, is [onomatopoeic](#), capturing the sad little flutter of Hope's flimsy "tinsel wing."

Toward the end of the poem, alliterative (and [consonant](#)) sounds again reflect the speaker's predicament:

Therefore the love which us doth bind,
But Fate so enviously debar,

The chime between "doth bind" and "debar" once again reflects the paradox here: the speaker's love is both forbidden and binding, impossible and persistent. Echoing sounds in contradictory words subtly underscore the idea that "opposition" and "conjunction" coexist here.

Elsewhere, alliterative sounds simply heighten powerful images—like the /w/ sounds the speaker uses when describing how "love's whole world on us doth wheel" in line 19, or the elegant /l/ sounds of "as lines, so loves" in line 25.

Where Alliteration appears in the poem:

- **Line 5:** "Despair"
- **Line 6:** "divine"
- **Line 7:** "flown"
- **Line 8:** "flapp'd"
- **Line 10:** "fixt"
- **Line 11:** "Fate"
- **Line 18:** "poles," "plac'd"
- **Line 19:** "world," "wheel"
- **Line 25:** "lines," "loves"
- **Line 29:** "doth bind"
- **Line 30:** "debars"

**VOCABULARY**

Rare (Line 1) - "Rare" here might mean both "unusual" and "lofty" or "fine."

Magnanimous (Line 5) - Generous.

Its tinsel wing (Line 8) - Hope's "tinsel wing" here suggests flimsiness and falseness. Hope's wings glitter promisingly, this image suggests, but can't necessarily get off the ground!

Fixt (Line 10) - That is, fixed—anchored, rooted, attached.

Betwixt (Line 12) - Between (i.e., between the lovers).

Close (Line 14) - Come together.

Giddy (Line 21) - Dizzy. (The heavens might be "giddy" because they're dizzyingly high, or because they appear to spin round and round.)

Convulsion (Line 22) - Spasm, earthquake.

Planisphere (Line 24) - A two-dimensional map of something spherical—often of the stars.

Oblique (Line 25) - Slanting.

Debars (Line 30) - Forbids, prevents.

Conjunction (Line 31) - Meeting.

**FORM, METER, & RHYME****FORM**

"The Definition of Love" uses a neat, straightforward form. Written in eight [quatrains](#) (or four-line stanzas) with a steady [iambic](#) rhythm and a simple ABAB [rhyme scheme](#), the poem in some ways looks and sounds as tidy as a folk song.

This deceptively simple form contains some elaborate, cerebral ideas about what the "definition of love" might be. The speaker's heady [conceit](#) of "two perfect loves" as mirrored parallel lines or opposite poles, unable to touch each other precisely *because* they're perfectly matched and perfectly

aligned, expresses heartbreak with mathematical elegance.

However, perhaps the poem's straightforward shape also chimes with the speaker's "Despair," based on the certainty that this couple can never be together. That fact seems to the speaker as simple and clear as a neatly rhymed quatrain.

METER

"The Definition of Love" is written in [iambic](#) tetrameter. That means that each line uses four iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "My love." Here's how that sounds in lines 1-2:

My love | is of | a birth | as rare
As 'tis | for ob- | ject strange | and high;

For the most part, this meter ticks along steadily. But in a couple of places, Marvell introduces variations. When Fate gets between the lovers in lines 17-20, for instance, the meter scrambles and tumbles:

And there- | fore her | decrees | of steel
Us as | the dis- | tant poles | have plac'd,
(Though love's | whole world | on us | doth wheel)
Not by | themselves | to be | embrac'd;

Lines 18 and 20 here both begin with a [trochee](#)—the opposite foot of an iamb, with a DUM-da rhythm. Pulling that strong stress forward makes those lines seem to stumble, as if tripping over the impediments Fate has put between the lovers. Line 19's powerful [spondee](#) (a foot with a DUM-DUM rhythm) on "whole world," meanwhile, strikes through the middle of the line just as the poem describes the speaker's "extended soul" striking through the center of the earth.

RHYME SCHEME

"The Definition of Love" uses a steady, neat ABAB [rhyme scheme](#). While that pattern holds true all the way through, some of the rhymes are [slant](#)—like the surprising chime between *tear* (in the sense of "rip," not the sense of "eye-water") and *planisphere* in the sixth stanza. (Note, though, that some rhymes that sound slant to a modern reader, like *high* and *Impossibility*, might well have been perfect in Marvell's 17th-century English accent.)

Like the poem's steady meter, these mostly straightforward rhymes form a striking contrast with elevated thoughts. This poem explains hopeless love through elaborate mathematical [metaphor](#), but does so in an unostentatious form. Perhaps that reflects how simple the speaker feels this predicament to be: the speaker is deeply in love yet can never be with their beloved, and those are just the plain, terrible facts.



SPEAKER

The poem's speaker is a resigned, despairing lover. From the very first, the speaker knew their love was born of "Despair" and "Impossibility": even when first falling in love, the speaker knew that they'd never get to be with the object of their affections.

The speaker finds consolation in the fact that this impossible love is also a perfect love. The couple's feelings for each other are as perfectly matched, as mathematically true, as two parallel lines. The thing about parallel lines is, they can never intersect: impossibility is part and parcel of this love's perfection.

That [conceit](#) might make the speaker come across as terribly romantic, or as rather cynical:

- On the one hand, this is someone with a vision of themselves and their beloved as equal and stalwart. Their love is in no way diminished by the fact that they can't ever be together; in fact, their love's impossibility reveals and enhances its perfection and strength.
- On the other, the poem's mathematical [metaphor](#) might suggest that perfect love and impossible love are one and the same. Lesser loves, the speaker says, are those which *aren't* perfectly parallel; imperfect matching allows lines to meet, creating an "angle" where they intersect. The implication might be that consummated love always falls away from a fantasy of perfection, sooner or later.

Either way (or both ways!), this lover has the labyrinthine brain of a Metaphysical poet.



SETTING

While there's no clear setting in "The Definition of Love," the speaker's [metaphors](#) present the reader with images of stars and planets: emotion on a cosmic scale. Doomed never to be with a beloved, the speaker pictures the two of them as opposite poles of "love's whole world": the love between them forms this globe's axis, but only *because* those poles can never meet.

Such images suggest that the poem's literal setting, in some sense, doesn't even matter to the speaker, who feels this predicament as one of planetary vastness. Wherever the speaker goes, they'll still be that lonely pole, forever bound to and separate from their beloved.

The poem's form, however, places this story in a specific moment of literary history. With its [conceits](#) of the lovers as poles and parallel lines, this cerebral poem clearly belongs to

the early 17th century and the world of the Metaphysical poets, writers who often built poems of deep feeling on a scaffold of complex and witty thought.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Andrew Marvell (1621-1678) was a famously elusive writer. In his political commitments and his poetry alike, he never stuck to one tradition or another: he's not quite a Cavalier poet and not quite a Metaphysical poet, though his work shows the marks and influences of both of those traditions.

For instance, Marvell's "[To His Coy Mistress](#)" is the gold standard of *carpe diem* poems (that is, poems in which a speaker tries to convince a lady to sleep with him, a theme for which the royalist Cavalier poets were [famous](#)). But if Marvell was a Cavalier, he wasn't a committed one. He was quick to turn his back on the cause when the Puritanical government of Oliver Cromwell rose to power—and then to cheerfully become a monarchist again when King Charles II returned from exile and resumed his throne.

"The Definition of Love," meanwhile, shows Marvell at his most Metaphysical. The Metaphysical poets never called themselves by that name: the later writer [Samuel Johnson](#) coined the term, using it to describe a set of 17th-century English writers who wrote witty, passionate, intricate poetry about love and God. Johnson didn't mean the term flatteringly, but it stuck, and is now used to describe luminaries including [John Donne](#), [George Herbert](#), and [Thomas Traherne](#). Along the lines of these contemporaries, Marvell here explores matters of the heart through cerebral [conceits](#).

Like many of Marvell's poems, "The Definition of Love" appeared posthumously in 1681, when a woman who claimed to be Marvell's wife (but was probably his hard-up housekeeper) published an assortment of his manuscripts in the hopes of collecting some royalties. If she hadn't, some of the world's [finest and most famous](#) poems might have been lost.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Andrew Marvell lived through one of the most dramatic episodes in English history: the English Civil War. In this earthshaking conflict, the Roundheads, led by Oliver Cromwell, rose up against the Cavaliers, forces loyal to King Charles I and to the monarchy in general. Cromwell's Roundheads argued for increased Parliamentary power as a curb on kingly tyranny.

This clash came to a dramatic climax in 1649 when Cromwell's triumphant forces tried, convicted, and beheaded Charles I for treason. This execution was a huge shock to a country whose recent monarchs had proclaimed the "divine right of kings," the idea that kings and queens were appointed by God.

Cromwell's stand against such ideas would start to look ironic when he began to exercise dictatorial control in his role as "Lord Protector." His power and popularity soon waned, and after he died, England invited Charles I's exiled son Charles II back to the throne, ushering in an era of luxury, elegance, and wit.

Marvell navigated these dangerous years by swearing his allegiance to whichever side happened to be dominant at the moment—a tricky strategy that he pulled off through brilliance, usefulness, and fast talking. If he held deeper political convictions than his actions suggest, they're hard to trace in his poetry. Though the tone and subject matter of his work often make him sound a lot like a Cavalier poet, he also wrote poems in praise of Cromwell and was close friends with the anti-monarchical [John Milton](#), whom he rescued from prison after Charles II resumed the throne.

- [Marvell's Legacy](#) — Read a review of a recent Marvell biography that discusses his literary afterlife. (<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2010/nov/06/andrew-marvell-nigel-smith-review>)
- [Miscellaneous Poems](#) — Take a look at images from a first edition of Marvell's *Miscellaneous Poems*—the posthumous poetry a woman who claimed to be his wife (but was likely his housekeeper) salvaged from his papers. (<https://www.bl.uk/collection-items/first-edition-of-andrew-marvells-poems-1681>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER ANDREW MARVELL POEMS

- [The Garden](#)
- [The Mower to the Glow-Worms](#)
- [To His Coy Mistress](#)
- [Upon Appleton House \(Excerpt\)](#)



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [A Brief Biography](#) — Learn more about Marvell's life and work via the Poetry Foundation. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/andrew-marvell>)
- [Portraits of Marvell](#) — See some portraits of Marvell as a young man via London's National Portrait Gallery. (<https://www.npg.org.uk/collections/search/person/mp02994/andrew-marvell>)
- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a reading of the poem. (https://youtu.be/-bG6us9NFd0?si=KJlr1k_2Pvc2a79Z)



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